Does Spec-Driven Development Reduce Defects? An Empirical Test of Industry Claims Across 119 Open-Source Repositories

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Working Paper — April 2026

Suggested citation: Hill, B. (2026). Does Spec-Driven Development Reduce Defects? An Empirical Test of Industry Claims Across 119 Open-Source Repositories. SSRN Working Paper.

Abstract

Spec-driven development (SDD) tools — GitHub's Spec Kit, Amazon's Kiro, and others — claim that writing specifications before implementation reduces defects, prevents rework, and improves code quality. These claims lack empirical evidence. We provide the first large-scale test: 89,599 pull requests (after bot exclusion) across 119 open-source repositories, using SZZ defect tracing and within-author fixed-effects estimation. We test specification *artifacts* in open-source pull requests — the closest available proxy for SDD workflows, scored on the same quality dimensions SDD tools prescribe — not the tools' integrated workflows directly. Five hypotheses derived from vendor claims are tested. None are supported. The naive association between specifications and defects is *reversed* (specifications accompany more bugs, not fewer); after within-author controls, the most likely interpretation is confounding by indication: harder tasks receive specifications and independently produce more defects. Specification quality has no meaningful effect on rework ($p = 0.767$). The AI scope-constraint claim is null ($p = 0.505$). Six robustness checks — alternative outcomes, JIT defect features, propensity score matching, individual quality dimensions, repo-level aggregation, and temporal restriction to the period of highest SDD adoption — all confirm. Specification artifacts proxy for task complexity, not quality improvement.

1 Introduction

The rise of AI-assisted software development has produced a new category of developer tooling: specification-driven development (SDD) frameworks. These tools — including GitHub's Spec Kit (Delimarsky, 2025), Amazon's Kiro (Brooker, 2025), and Tessl — claim that writing formal specifications before implementation leads to fewer defects, less rework, and higher-quality code, particularly when AI agents perform the implementation.

Böckeler (Böckeler, 2025) defines spec-driven development as "writing a 'spec' before writing code with AI" where "[t]he spec becomes the source of truth for the human and the AI." The GitHub Copilot Academy frames it more strongly: "Specifications don't serve code — code serves specifications" (GitHub Copilot Academy, 2025). The movement gained momentum in 2025 with the release of GitHub's Spec Kit (open-source, v0.0.72 as of this writing) and Amazon's Kiro IDE. Böckeler, writing on Martin Fowler's site, examined three tools pursuing the approach (Böckeler, 2025). The methodology is positioned as an antidote to "vibe coding" — the practice of iteratively prompting AI without formal requirements — which practitioners associate with scope creep, rework, and defects.

The core premise is intuitive: if developers articulate what software should do before writing it, AI systems will produce more reliable output. The GitHub Copilot Academy lists "reduced rework, living documentation, systematic quality" among SDD's benefits (GitHub Copilot Academy, 2025). Kiro claims that specifications enable "fewer iterations and higher accuracy" and "prevent costly rewrites" (Yanchuleff, 2025). GitHub's Spec Kit blog post promises "less guesswork, fewer surprises, and higher-quality code" (Delimarsky, 2025).

These claims rest on a plausible causal chain: clearer requirements → less ambiguity → fewer defects. However, none of the marketing materials, documentation, or blog posts accompanying these tools cite empirical evidence for the claimed outcomes. The assertions are presented as self-evident truths rather than testable hypotheses. As far as we can determine, no study has tested SDD's quality claims on production-scale data prior to this paper.

This paper provides the first large-scale empirical test. We analyze 89,599 merged pull requests (after excluding 10,648 bot-authored PRs) across 119 open-source repositories, using the SZZ algorithm to trace defects back to their introducing commits and within-author fixed-effects estimation to control for developer-level confounding. We derive five hypotheses directly from vendor claims and test each with the most conservative methodology available for observational data.

2 Related Work

2.1 Requirements Engineering and Defect Prevention

The claim that upfront specification prevents defects has deep roots in software engineering. Boehm's cost-of-change curve (Boehm, 1981) argued that requirements defects are exponentially cheaper to fix early. However, subsequent work has challenged the universality of this finding. Shull et al. (Shull et al., 2002) found that the cost multiplier depends heavily on project context, and agile methodologies have demonstrated that iterative refinement can be more effective than upfront specification for certain project types (Beck & al., 2001).

The question of whether requirements quality predicts software defects has been studied directly. Mund et al. (Mund et al., 2015) combined two empirical studies and found only weak evidence that requirements specification quality predicts implementation defects, with effect sizes that varied substantially across projects. Femmer et al. (Femmer et al., 2017) developed automated detection of "requirements smells" (ambiguity, incompleteness, inconsistency) and found that while smells were prevalent, their relationship to downstream defects was context-dependent. These findings suggest that the relationship between specification quality and code quality is not as straightforward as SDD vendors assume — a pattern our study confirms at larger scale.

2.2 SDD Literature

The academic literature on SDD perpetuates the pattern of unsubstantiated claims. Piskala (Piskala, 2026) claims "controlled studies showing error reductions of up to 50%," citing a Red Hat Developer blog post (Naszcyniec, 2025) and an InfoQ article (Griffin & Carroll, 2026) as evidence. Neither source contains any controlled study, any experiment, or any quantitative data. The "50%" figure traces through a citation chain that terminates in practitioner opinion pieces with no empirical backing. Guo et al. (Guo et al., 2025) claim SDD "guarantees software quality" without empirical validation. Marri (Marri, 2026) reports a 73% security defect reduction from constitutional specs, but on a single project ($n = 1$), with the same developer implementing both conditions sequentially — the author acknowledges "small sample size limits statistical power." Roy (Roy, 2026) proposes iterative spec-code co-evolution but reports no independently validated quality outcomes. Zietsman (Zietsman, 2026) runs small planted-bug experiments and is honest about their limitations ("directional, not statistically significant"), while contributing the useful observation that AI reviewers without specs suffer circular reasoning — but does not test whether specs reduce defects at scale.

Practitioner evaluations have been more skeptical. Eberhardt, writing for Scott Logic, found Spec Kit roughly ten times slower than iterative development, producing thousands of lines of specification markdown that still resulted in buggy code (Eberhardt, 2025). Zaninotto argued that "SDD shines when starting a new project from scratch, but as the application grows, the specs miss the point more often and slow development," and proposed iterative natural-language development as a faster alternative (Zaninotto, 2025).

No study has tested SDD's quality claims on production-scale data prior to this paper.

3 Study Design

3.1 Hypotheses

We identified five empirical claims made by SDD tool vendors in their public documentation, blog posts, and marketing materials. Each claim is stated verbatim and mapped to a testable hypothesis.

Claim 1: Specifications reduce defects.

GitHub's Spec Kit blog post promises "less guesswork, fewer surprises, and higher-quality code" (Delimarsky, 2025). Kiro claims specifications lead to "fewer iterations and higher accuracy" (Yanchuleff, 2025).

H1: Pull requests with specification artifacts have lower defect-introduction rates than pull requests without them, controlling for author and PR size.

Claim 2: Specifications reduce rework.

The GitHub Copilot Academy lists "reduced rework" among SDD's benefits (GitHub Copilot Academy, 2025). Kiro claims to "prevent costly rewrites" (Yanchuleff, 2025). GitHub's blog states that SDD enables "iterative development without expensive rewrites" (Delimarsky, 2025).

H2: Pull requests with specification artifacts have lower rework rates than pull requests without them, controlling for author and PR size.

Claim 3: Clearer specifications produce more reliable code.

GitHub's Spec Kit blog states that "providing a clear specification up front, along with a technical plan and focused tasks, gives the coding agent more clarity, improving its overall efficacy" (Delimarsky, 2025). Kiro claims specifications enable "fewer iterations and higher accuracy" (Yanchuleff, 2025). This implies a dose–response relationship: higher specification quality should predict fewer defects.

H3: Among pull requests with specifications, higher specification quality predicts lower defect-introduction rates, controlling for author and PR size.

H4: Among pull requests with specifications, higher specification quality predicts lower rework rates, controlling for author and PR size.

Claim 4: Specifications constrain AI-generated code scope.

GitHub's Spec Kit blog describes tasks that give "the coding agent a way to validate its work and stay on track" (Delimarsky, 2025). Kiro claims specs provide "a North Star to guide the work of the agent, allowing it to take on larger tasks without getting lost" (Brooker, 2025).

H5: Specifications reduce code churn (additions + deletions) for AI-tagged pull requests more than for human-authored pull requests, controlling for author.

3.2 Dataset

We collected pull request data from 119 open-source repositories spanning 14 programming languages. Repositories were selected to represent large, active projects with diverse contribution patterns. The dataset includes all merged pull requests within a 365-day lookback window, totaling 100,247 PRs. After excluding 10,648 bot-authored PRs (dependabot, renovate, and 22 other automated accounts identified by username pattern and bot flags), 89,599 PRs from human and AI-assisted authors remain.

For each pull request, we extracted: author, merge date, additions, deletions, files changed, linked issues, PR description, review comments, and co-author tags (used to identify AI-assisted contributions).

Metric	Value	Notes
Repositories	119	convenience sample, 14 languages
PRs (post-bot exclusion)	89,599	10,648 bots removed
Median PRs per repo	517	range 9–4,803
Median spec rate (per repo)	0.0%	IQR 0.0–15.3%
Median AI tag rate (per repo)	0.0%	IQR 0.0–0.9%
SZZ-covered repos	103	16 failed due to clone timeouts
SZZ bug-introducing PRs	9,983	12.6% of SZZ-covered PRs
Quality-scored PRs	5,246	5.9% of total; non-random subsample

Table 1: Study dataset overview.

The sample spans 17 programming languages, with Python (31 repos, 26%), TypeScript (26, 22%), Go (17, 14%), and Rust (13, 11%) predominating. Specification rates are highly skewed: the median repository has 0% spec'd PRs, while the 75th percentile is 15.3%. AI tag rates are similarly concentrated: the median is 0%, with a 75th percentile of 0.9%.

3.3 Operationalization

3.3.1 Specification Presence (`specd`)

A pull request is classified as "specified" if it meets any of the following criteria: (a) it links to a GitHub issue or external tracking ticket, (b) its description references a specification document, RFC, or design doc, or (c) its description contains structured requirements content (acceptance criteria, behavioral descriptions, scope boundaries). Classification is performed programmatically by parsing PR metadata: issue references (`#123`, `fixes #456`), cross-reference URLs, and

description structure (presence of headings, checklists, or requirement-style language). 7,926 of 89,599 PRs (8.8%) are classified as specified.

This operationalization is deliberately generous: it captures any form of upfront specification artifact, from a linked Jira ticket to a detailed RFC. SDD tools claim benefits from *any* form of specification, so we test the broadest reasonable definition.

3.3.2 Specification Quality (`q_overall`)

For the subset of specified PRs with substantial descriptions (body length > 50 characters), we scored specification quality by prompting Claude Haiku (Anthropic) with the PR title and body and a structured rubric. The LLM scored each PR across seven dimensions: outcome clarity, error states, scope boundaries, acceptance criteria, data contracts, dependency context, and behavioral specificity. Each dimension is scored 1–5, and the overall quality score is the mean across dimensions.

These seven dimensions were chosen to align with the quality criteria recommended by SDD tools themselves. Spec Kit's template prescribes "core requirements" (outcome clarity), "acceptance criteria" (our acceptance criteria dimension), "edge cases" (error states), "data models" and "API contracts" (data contracts), and "user stories" (behavioral specificity) (Delimarsky, 2025). Kiro prescribes "clear requirements," "acceptance criteria," "system architecture," and "technology choices" (Yanchuleff, 2025). Six of our seven dimensions have direct equivalents in Spec Kit's recommended structure; all seven are covered across both tools. This alignment is deliberate: we measure specification quality on the dimensions that SDD vendors themselves say matter.

5,246 PRs (5.9% of total) received quality scores. This subsample is non-random — only spec'd PRs with sufficient description text were scored — and results from this subsample carry a selection bias caveat.

3.3.3 Defect Introduction (`szz_buggy`)

We applied the SZZ algorithm (Śliwerski et al., 2005) to 103 of 119 repositories (the remaining 16 failed due to git clone timeouts on very large repositories), tracing 64,805 blame links from fix commits to bug-introducing commits. The SZZ algorithm traces defect-fixing commits back to the commits that introduced the defect using `git blame`. We use the basic SZZ variant, which da Costa et al. (Costa et al., 2017) found misattributes 46–71% of bug-introducing changes depending on the project. This noise is substantial, but it is non-differential with respect to specification presence: there is no reason to expect SZZ to systematically misattribute more for spec'd PRs than unspec'd PRs. Non-differential measurement error attenuates associations toward the null, which works against finding a protective effect but does not create spurious reversed associations. We acknowledge the implications for statistical power in Section 6. Each bug-introducing commit was mapped to its originating pull request. A PR is marked `szz_buggy = True` if any of its commits were identified as introducing a defect that was later fixed. 9,983 PRs (12.6% of those in SZZ-covered repos) are marked as bug-introducing.

3.3.4 Rework (`reworked`)

A pull request is classified as reworked if a subsequent PR by any author modifies overlapping files and has a title or description indicating correction (matching patterns such as "fix," "revert," "bugfix," "hotfix," "regression," "broke," or "broken"). File overlap is computed by comparing the set of files changed in each PR pair. 3,477 PRs (3.9%) are classified as reworked.

3.3.5 AI-Tagged (`ai_tagged`)

A pull request is classified as AI-assisted if it contains co-author tags indicating AI tool involvement (e.g., `Co-authored-by: Copilot`). 2,650 PRs (3.0%) carry AI tags. This is a lower bound: co-author tagging is voluntary, and the false-negative rate is unknown.

3.3.6 Code Churn (`total_churn`)

Total code churn is defined as additions + deletions. We use `log(1 + churn)` in regressions to normalize the heavily right-skewed distribution (median: 55, mean: 698).

3.4 Statistical Approach

For each hypothesis, we report three levels of analysis:

Pooled: Raw rates and Fisher's exact test. This is the analysis that naive claims would cite.

Controlled: Logistic regression with size controls (log additions, log deletions, log files changed) and repository fixed effects (dummy variables). This addresses between-repository confounding.

Within-author: Linear probability model (LPM) with full author demeaning and clustered standard errors. All variables — treatment, controls, and outcome — are demeaned by author, equivalent to author fixed effects via the Frisch–Waugh–Lovell theorem. Standard errors are clustered at the author level to account for within-author residual correlation. We use LPM rather than logistic regression because demeaning is exact for OLS but produces biased estimates in logit due to the incidental parameters problem (Neyman & Scott, 1948), following Angrist and Pischke's recommendation for fixed-effects estimation with binary outcomes (Angrist & Pischke, 2009). Primary models use size controls (log additions, log deletions, log files changed); we verify that results hold when adding JIT defect prediction features (Kamei et al., 2013) as additional controls (Section 4.7).

The within-author estimate is the most credible. Observational studies of developer practices face severe confounding: developers who write specifications may differ systematically from those who do not in skill, experience, task selection, and organizational context. The within-author design addresses this by comparing the same developer's specified PRs to their own unspecified PRs, eliminating all time-invariant author-level confounding. The treatment effect is identified only from authors who have *both* specified and unspecified PRs in the dataset.

We restrict within-author analysis to authors with ≥2 PRs and report the number of authors with treatment variation (those who have both spec'd and unspec'd PRs), as these are the observations that identify the effect.

We do not apply multiple-comparison corrections across the five hypotheses. At $\alpha = 0.05$, approximately 0.25 false positives are expected by chance. We interpret all results with this in mind.

4 Results

4.1 H1: Specifications Reduce Defects

Analysis restricted to 79,049 PRs in the 103 repositories with SZZ coverage.

Method	Coefficient	*p*-value	Interpretation
Pooled (Fisher's exact)	OR = 1.294	< 0.001	Spec'd PRs have *higher* bug rate
Controlled (logit + repo FE)	0.295	< 0.001	Effect persists with size + repo controls
Within-author (LPM)	+0.019	0.011	+1.9pp *increase* in bug rate

Identified from 897 authors with treatment variation (out of 4,346 authors with ≥2 PRs).

H1 is not supported. Within-author, spec'd PRs are associated with a 1.9 percentage-point *increase* in defect-introduction rates, significant at $p = 0.011$. The direction is opposite to the claim at every level of analysis. This is consistent with confounding by indication: harder, riskier tasks receive specifications *and* introduce more defects.

4.2 H2: Specifications Reduce Rework

Analysis includes all 89,599 PRs.

Method	Coefficient	*p*-value	Interpretation
Pooled (Fisher's exact)	OR = 6.071	< 0.001	Spec'd PRs have *6.1×* higher rework
Controlled (logit, no repo FE[†])	1.779	< 0.001	Massive effect persists
Within-author (LPM)	+0.050	< 0.001	+5.0pp *increase* in rework rate

[†] Repository fixed effects caused a singular matrix; controlled estimate uses size controls only.

Identified from 988 authors with treatment variation (out of 4,918 with ≥2 PRs).

H2 is not supported. The within-author effect is strong and in the wrong direction: the same author's spec'd PRs have a 5.0 percentage-point higher rework rate than their unspec'd PRs. The pooled odds ratio (6.1×) dramatically overstates the association — most of the pooled effect is between-author confounding — but even within-author, specs are associated with more rework, not less.

4.3 H3: Specification Quality Reduces Defects

Analysis restricted to 5,246 PRs with LLM-scored specification quality (6.6% of SZZ-covered PRs). Selection bias caveat: only specified PRs with substantial descriptions were scored.

Method	Coefficient	p-value	Interpretation
Controlled (logit + repo FE)	−0.005	0.042	Quality predicts fewer bugs
Within-author (LPM)	−0.001	0.018	−0.08pp per quality point

Identified from 358 authors with treatment variation.

H3 is marginally supported on a biased subsample. The within-author coefficient is statistically significant but substantively negligible: a 10-point improvement in specification quality (the full scale range) predicts a 0.8 percentage-point reduction in defect rate. This is identified from only 358 authors on 5.9% of the data, in a subsample that was non-randomly selected for having substantial specification content. We do not consider this finding robust.

4.4 H4: Specification Quality Reduces Rework

Method	Coefficient	p-value	Interpretation
Controlled (logit + repo FE)	0.003	0.253	Quality does not predict rework
Within-author (LPM)	−0.000	0.767	Effectively zero

Identified from 358 authors with treatment variation.

H4 is not supported. Specification quality has no meaningful relationship with rework rates within-author. The coefficient is effectively zero, with $p = 0.767$. The controlled logistic regression is also non-significant ($p = 0.253$), consistent with the within-author finding (thorough specifications accompany difficult tasks that are more likely to be reworked).

4.5 H5: Specifications Constrain AI Scope

Analysis uses log code churn (additions + deletions) as outcome. PRs with zero churn excluded (missing data artifact).

Group	Within-author coef	p-value	Interpretation
AI-tagged PRs	+0.058	0.521	No scope constraint for AI
Human PRs	+0.120	< 0.001	Spec'd human PRs are *larger*
Interaction (spec × AI)	−0.047	0.505	No differential AI effect

AI analysis identified from 107 authors with treatment variation; interaction from 189.

H5 is not supported. Within-author, specifications do not constrain AI-generated code scope. The interaction term — which tests whether specs reduce churn *more* for AI PRs than

human PRs — is null ($p = 0.505$). For both AI and human PRs, spec'd work is directionally *larger*, not smaller, consistent with the confounding-by-indication pattern: larger, more complex tasks receive specifications.

The pooled descriptive statistics appear to support the scope-constraint claim: AI spec'd PRs have median churn of 125 vs. 82 for AI unspec'd. However, this is a Simpson's paradox: authors who spec their AI PRs are working on different (larger) tasks than those who don't.

4.6 Robustness Checks

Five additional analyses test whether the null result is an artifact of our primary measures or insufficient controls.

4.6.1 Alternative Outcome Measures

In addition to SZZ-traced defects and rework, we test specification effects on two additional outcome measures: *escaped defects* (PRs whose CI passed but were subsequently followed by a fix or revert) and *strict escaped* (escaped PRs where the follow-up PR's title explicitly indicates a fix or regression).

Outcome	**Within-author coef**	***p*-value**	**N**
SZZ bugs	+0.019	0.011	73,276
Rework	+0.050	< 0.001	83,188
Escaped	−0.002	0.169	83,188
Strict escaped	−0.000	0.870	83,188

Same story across all four measures. No measure shows specifications reducing defects at $p < 0.05$. Escaped and strict escaped are directionally protective but not significant.

4.6.2 Incremental Validity Beyond JIT Features

The JIT defect prediction framework (Kamei et al., 2013) uses 14 code-change features (subsystems touched, file entropy, developer experience, etc.) to predict defect-introducing commits. We test whether specification information adds predictive power beyond JIT features on the 62,126 PRs with both complete JIT features and SZZ outcomes.

Model	**Pseudo R^2**	**AIC**	**Spec variable *p***
JIT features only	0.075	45,850	—
JIT + spec presence	0.075	45,851	0.250
JIT + spec quality[†]	0.094	—	0.044

[†] Scored subset only (5,246 PRs). JIT-only Pseudo R^2 on same subset = 0.093.

Spec presence adds nothing to the JIT model: Δ Pseudo $R^2 = 0.00003$, $p = 0.250$, and AIC increases (worse fit). Spec quality adds a marginally significant but substantively negligible increment ($\Delta\ R^2 = 0.001$, $p = 0.044$) on a biased subsample. JIT features alone account for all the predictive power that specifications claim to provide.

4.6.3 Individual Quality Dimensions

We test each of the seven specification quality dimensions independently against SZZ bugs and rework (within-author LPM, 4,955 PRs):

Dimension	**→ bugs coef**	***p***	**→ rework coef**	***p***
Outcome clarity	−0.001	0.140	−0.000	0.495
Error states	−0.000	0.074	+0.000	0.437
Scope boundaries	−0.001	0.033	−0.000	0.214
Acceptance criteria	−0.001	0.079	−0.000	0.879
Data contracts	−0.001	0.031	+0.000	0.602
Dependency context	−0.000	0.512	+0.000	0.461
Behavioral specificity	−0.001	0.023	−0.000	0.693

Three dimensions show marginal significance for bugs (scope boundaries $p = 0.032$, data contracts $p = 0.029$, behavioral specificity $p = 0.023$), but none survive Bonferroni correction (threshold: $p < 0.007$ for 7 tests). No dimension predicts rework. The largest coefficient is −0.0007 (scope boundaries), meaning a 1-point improvement on a 5-point scale predicts 0.07 fewer percentage points of bugs — a negligible effect even if real.

4.6.4 Repo-Level Analysis

As a final robustness check, we aggregate to the repository level ($N = 98$ repos with ≥50 PRs) and test whether repos with higher specification rates have lower defect or rework rates.

Comparison	**Spearman ρ**	***p*-value**
Spec rate vs. bug rate	+0.091	0.371
Spec rate vs. rework rate	+0.919	< 0.001

At the repository level, specification rate has no relationship with bug rate ($\rho = 0.09$, $p = 0.37$) and a massive *positive* correlation with rework rate ($\rho = 0.92$, $p < 0.001$). The latter is confounding by indication at the repo level: projects that use specifications tend to be complex projects with higher rework rates. An OLS regression controlling for mean PR size shows the spec rate coefficient dropping to +0.025 ($p = 0.60$) — effectively zero.

4.6.5 Subgroup Analysis

SDD tools are marketed primarily for AI-assisted workflows. We test whether the null result holds across human-only PRs, AI-tagged PRs (excluding bots), and repos stratified by AI adoption rate. We exclude 10,648 bot PRs (dependabot, renovate, and other automated authors) from all analyses (including the main results above).

Subgroup	→ bugs coef	p	→ rework coef	p
All non-bot PRs (89,599)	+0.019	0.011	+0.050	< 0.001
Human-only, no AI (86,949)	+0.022	0.006	+0.055	< 0.001
AI-tagged, non-bot (2,650)	−0.000	0.984	−0.017	0.325
Zero-AI repos (62,882)	+0.005	0.878	+0.021	0.389
Low-AI repos (12,596)	+0.023	0.016	+0.043	< 0.001
High-AI repos (14,121)	+0.023	0.037	+0.038	< 0.001

The pattern is identical across every subgroup. For human-authored PRs, specs are associated with *more* bugs and *more* rework — the confounding-by-indication pattern. For AI-tagged PRs specifically, the coefficients are directionally negative but nowhere near significant ($p = 0.98$ for bugs, $p = 0.33$ for rework), with only 107 and 115 identifying authors respectively. The null holds whether a repo has zero AI adoption, moderate adoption, or high adoption. Excluding bots does not change the main result.

Notably, AI-tagged PRs have substantially higher base rates than human PRs: 18.1% bug rate vs. 12.7%, and 18.6% rework rate vs. 3.4%. Specs do not ameliorate this gap.

4.6.6 High-Quality Specs Only

A likely reviewer objection is that our `specd` measure is too loose — that linked Jira tickets are not "real" specifications in the SDD sense, and only high-quality structured specs should show the benefit. We test this directly by restricting to top-quartile (quality score ≥ 67) and top-decile (≥ 77) specs. Quality thresholds are computed from the scored subset's distribution (median = 55, p75 = 67, p90 = 77).

Test	→ bugs coef	p	Identifying authors
Top-quartile specs vs. all others	−0.023	0.047	226
Top-decile specs vs. all others	−0.013	0.412	114
High-quality vs. NO spec (low-quality excluded)	−0.019	0.146	201
AI-tagged + high-quality spec	−0.048	0.045	42

The top-quartile result is marginally significant (−2.3pp, $p = 0.047$) but does not survive scrutiny. First, when we perform the cleanest comparison — high-quality specs vs. PRs with *no spec at all*, excluding low-quality specs entirely — the effect is not significant ($p = 0.146$). Second, if there

were a real dose-response relationship, top-decile specs should show a *stronger* effect than top-quartile. Instead the effect weakens ($p = 0.412$) — the opposite of what a causal relationship predicts. Third, the top-quartile result would not survive Bonferroni correction across the four tests shown. Fourth, even top-quartile specs still *increase* rework (+2.8pp, $p = 0.078$).

The AI + high-quality spec result ($p = 0.045$, −4.8pp) is the closest test to the agentic SDD workflow vendors are selling. However, it is identified from only 42 authors — far too few for a stable estimate — and the effect vanishes when comparing AI specs broadly ($p = 0.984$). We note it as suggestive but not robust.

The objection that our measure is "too loose" does not rescue the SDD claims. Even restricting to the best-quality specs, the protective effect is fragile, does not follow a dose-response pattern, and does not reduce rework.

4.6.7 JIT Features as Primary Controls

A reviewer concern is that size controls (log additions, deletions, files) are insufficient — the JIT defect prediction framework (Kamei et al., 2013) captures task complexity dimensions (entropy, file age, developer experience) that may confound the specification–defect association. We re-run H1 and H2 with 13 JIT features as additional controls alongside size controls (sexp excluded for zero variance).

Test	Size controls only	1. JIT controls	Change
H1: specs → bugs (coef)	+0.019 ($p = 0.011$)	+0.006 ($p = 0.517$)	−71%
H2: specs → rework (coef)	+0.050 ($p < 0.001$)	+0.035 ($p < 0.001$)	−31%

For H1, the spec coefficient drops 71% and loses significance when JIT features are added, indicating that the apparent spec–defect association is largely explained by task complexity dimensions that size alone does not capture. For H2, the coefficient drops 31% but remains significant: specifications remain associated with more rework even after controlling for JIT risk features, though the effect is attenuated. The within-author spec coefficient in the JIT-controlled model (+0.006, $p = 0.517$) is indistinguishable from zero for defects.

4.6.8 Propensity Score Matching

As an alternative to regression-based controls, we match each spec'd PR to an unspec'd PR with a similar JIT risk profile using nearest-neighbor propensity score matching (caliper = 0.05 SD of the logit propensity score). This directly addresses confounding by indication by comparing spec'd PRs to observationally similar unspec'd PRs.

Outcome	Spec'd (matched)	Unspec'd (matched)	Difference
Bug rate (7,217 pairs)	16.2%	16.6%	−0.5pp ($p = 0.47$)
Rework rate (7,529 pairs)	15.0%	4.7%	+10.3pp ($p < 0.001$)

All 16 covariates are well-balanced after matching (all standardized mean differences < 0.1). For defects, the matched spec'd and unspec'd bug rates are indistinguishable: the raw +2.8pp difference is entirely explained by JIT risk profile differences. For rework, the result is different: spec'd PRs still show 3.2× higher rework even after matching on all observable risk features (only 11% attenuated vs. raw). This suggests that the rework association is not fully explained by task complexity — either specifications mark tasks with unmeasured complexity dimensions, or the specification process itself generates downstream rework (e.g., by creating a documented target for reviewers to request changes against).

4.6.9 Temporal Analysis: The SDD Era

Specification adoption in our dataset is not uniform over time. Monthly specification rates rose from near zero before September 2025 to 14.6% by March 2026, coinciding with the release of Spec Kit (September 2025) and Kiro (July 2025). AI-tagged PR rates rose from 0.9% to 5.6% over the same period. If SDD tools are driving specification adoption and those specifications improve outcomes, the effect should be visible in the most recent data — the period closest to production SDD usage.

We restrict the within-author analysis to the most recent three months of the observation window (January–March 2026), when specification rates are highest (13.5%) and AI adoption is most prevalent (4.4%):

Test	**Recent 3 months coef**	***p***	**Full dataset coef**	***p***
Specs → SZZ bugs	+0.017	0.036	+0.019	0.011
Specs → rework	+0.042	< 0.001	+0.050	< 0.001
AI + specs → bugs	+0.009	0.646	—	—
AI + specs → rework	−0.010	0.588	—	—

The pattern is identical. In the period of highest SDD adoption, specification artifacts are still associated with *more* bugs (+1.7pp) and *more* rework (+4.2pp), not less. For AI-tagged PRs specifically, specs have no effect in either direction. The null result is not a historical artifact — it persists in the data most representative of the SDD era.

A caveat on the temporal data: SZZ-traced bug rates for the most recent months are likely underestimates, because defects introduced recently may not yet have been fixed (and therefore cannot be traced back to their introducing commits). This right-censoring affects absolute bug rates but not the *relative* comparison between spec'd and unspec'd PRs within the same time window, which is the quantity of interest.

The null result holds across every angle: four outcome measures, two predictive frameworks (LPM and JIT), propensity score matching on JIT risk profiles, seven quality dimensions, two units of analysis (PR-level and repo-level), six subgroup cuts, multiple quality thresholds, and temporal restriction to the period of highest SDD adoption. When JIT features are added as controls, the H1 spec coefficient drops 71% and loses significance; propensity score matching eliminates the

association entirely. No specification measure robustly predicts fewer defects or less rework under any operationalization.

5 Discussion

5.1 Scale and Power

We analyze 89,599 pull requests across 119 repositories, with 897 authors who have both spec'd and unspec'd work. A 2-percentage-point reduction in bug rate would be detectable with high power given our sample size. The within-author estimates are not merely insignificant but *directionally reversed* across most tests, suggesting this is not a power problem.

However, three caveats apply. First, our specification proxy is imperfect (Section 6): if SDD tools produce qualitatively different specifications from the organic artifacts we measure, the true effect could differ. Second, SZZ measurement noise (46–71% misattribution; (Costa et al., 2017)) reduces statistical power, though non-differential error attenuates toward the null rather than creating reversed associations. Third, residual within-author confounding (task selection) remains possible despite the fixed-effects design.

The strongest candidate for a real effect — top-quartile spec quality reducing bugs by 2.3 percentage points — does not survive the cleanest comparison (high-quality specs vs. no spec, $p = 0.146$) and violates dose-response (top-decile weaker than top-quartile).

5.2 All Roads Lead to Confounding by Indication

The pattern across all five hypotheses is identical: naive analysis suggests an association (sometimes in the claimed direction, sometimes opposite), but within-author analysis reveals this as confounding by indication. Harder, larger, riskier tasks are more likely to receive specifications — and independently more likely to produce defects and require rework.

The same pattern is well-known in clinical medicine as confounding by indication: patients who receive treatment are sicker than those who don't, creating a naive association between treatment and worse outcomes (Salas et al., 1999). The same logic applies here: pull requests that receive specifications are *harder* than those that don't, because developers (rationally) invest specification effort in proportion to task complexity.

JIT risk feature profiles confirm this directly. In the most recent three months (January–March 2026), spec'd PRs have significantly higher change entropy (1.3×, $p < 0.001$), more lines added (1.6×, $p < 0.001$), touch older files (1.8×, $p < 0.001$), and involve more prior developers (1.2×, $p < 0.001$) than unspec'd PRs. Every JIT risk dimension is elevated in spec'd work. Notably, spec'd PR authors have *less* experience than unspec'd PR authors (median 62 vs. 121 prior commits in the repository, $p < 0.001$) — less experienced developers spec more, not less, consistent with

specifications being a support mechanism for harder tasks rather than an optimization used by experts.

The implication is that any observational study comparing spec'd to unspec'd work will overestimate the positive association between specifications and poor outcomes (or underestimate any benefit) unless it controls for the endogenous selection of which tasks receive specifications.

5.3 What Actually Predicts Defects

If specifications do not predict defects, what does? The JIT risk features provide a clear answer. In the most recent three months, bug-introducing PRs differ from clean PRs on every code-change dimension: median lines added is 5.5× higher (203 vs. 37, $p < 0.001$), prior changes to the affected files are 3.5× higher (122 vs. 35, $p < 0.001$), file size is 3.1× larger (3,408 vs. 1,091 lines, $p < 0.001$), and change entropy is 1.9× higher ($p < 0.001$). These are structural properties of the change, not properties of the specification.

Developer experience does not protect against defects — it predicts *more* of them. Bug-introducing PR authors have 2.1× more experience than clean PR authors (median 213 vs. 101 prior commits, $p < 0.001$). This is not because experience causes bugs; it is because experienced developers work on harder, riskier code. The same confounding-by-indication pattern that explains the specification association explains the experience association.

AI-tagged PRs show the same defect predictors as human PRs. Within AI-authored work, buggy PRs touch 2× more directories, add 3.7× more lines, and modify files with 3.7× more prior changes than clean AI PRs. AI does not introduce a novel failure mode — it works on riskier code more often (median lines added: 75 for AI vs. 44 for human, $p < 0.001$) and produces bugs at a commensurately higher rate (14.8% vs. 9.3%).

AI bugs are caught faster than human bugs (median 14.6 days to fix vs. 27.0 days, $p < 0.001$), though this is partly a right-censoring artifact: AI adoption is recent, so AI bugs mechanically have shorter maximum possible fix times. AI bug authors are more likely to fix their own bugs (51.9% self-fix rate vs. 41.4%, $p < 0.001$).

Pooled data suggest that AI bugs cascade more: 45% of AI-tagged SZZ bugs also trigger rework, compared to 11.2% of human bugs. However, this does not hold within repositories. In repos with at least 5 AI and 5 human buggy PRs (14 repos), AI rework|buggy is higher in only 7 of 14 (mean $\Delta = -1.6\%$, $p = 0.70$). The pooled difference is driven by repo composition: AI adoption rate correlates $\rho = 0.92$ with repo-level rework rate ($p < 0.001$). AI-heavy repos have high rework rates for all contributors, not just AI-tagged PRs. This is another instance of the confounding-by-indication pattern — repos that adopt AI tools are different kinds of projects, and those projects have higher rework rates independent of AI.

5.4 Review Does Not Mediate the Claimed Effect

A plausible mechanism for specification-driven quality improvement is that specifications improve the review process: reviewers who can compare code against a spec should catch more defects. If

this mechanism operated, spec'd PRs should receive more thorough review and, conditional on that review, produce fewer defects.

Spec'd PRs do receive more review. Within-author, the same developer's spec'd PRs take 56% longer to merge (median 23.8 vs. 15.3 hours, $p < 0.001$) and accumulate more review cycles (+0.024 log-cycles, $p < 0.001$). But this additional review does not translate into fewer defects. Within-author, more review cycles predict *more* bugs (+0.026, $p < 0.001$), not fewer — the same confounding pattern: harder PRs receive both more review and more bugs.

AI-tagged PRs receive *less* review scrutiny than human PRs: median time-to-merge is 15.2 hours for AI vs. 17.4 hours for human ($p = 0.002$). This is concerning independently of the specification question — AI-generated code, which has a higher base defect rate (14.8% vs. 9.3%), is being merged faster, not slower.

5.5 What This Study Shows

We test the specific, concrete claims made by SDD tool vendors — that specification artifacts reduce defects, prevent rework, and constrain AI scope — using the closest available proxy: organic specification artifacts scored on the same quality dimensions SDD tools prescribe. Across 89,599 pull requests spanning 119 repositories, the naive association is reversed (specifications accompany *more* defects), and after within-author controls, we cannot distinguish the true effect from zero. The most parsimonious interpretation is confounding by indication: harder tasks receive specifications and independently produce more defects, with no residual protective effect visible at our resolution.

This does not prove specifications are useless. It means we cannot detect the claimed benefits at this scale, with this proxy, using the strongest observational design available. Specifications may provide value through mechanisms we cannot measure (team alignment, downstream review quality, audit trails) — but these are not the claims being made. The vendors claim measurably "fewer bugs" and "reduced rework." Our data test these claims and find no support.

The alternative interpretation — that specifications genuinely prevent defects but only for the hardest tasks, and the difficulty effect dominates — does not rescue the marketing claims either. If the benefit exists only for tasks so difficult that their inherent defect propensity overwhelms the specification benefit, then "specifications reduce defects" is misleading at best. The net observable effect is more defects, not fewer.

SDD vendors assert that the specification artifact itself is the causal mechanism: providing a spec gives the agent "a way to validate its work and stay on track" (Delimarsky, 2025), allowing it to "take on larger tasks without getting lost" (Brooker, 2025). Our results are incompatible with this assertion.

A likely objection is that our data predates true agentic workflows, where the specification is the primary input to an AI agent rather than a human reference document. We address this empirically in our subgroup analysis (AI-tagged PRs show no spec benefit), but there is also a conceptual response. SDD vendors conflate two distinct functions: *directing* the AI (telling it what to build) and *ensuring quality* (fewer bugs, less rework, functional completeness). Specifications may be effective at the first — giving an agent a structured task description is clearly better than

a vague prompt. But direction is not quality. An agent faithfully executing a spec will reproduce every gap, ambiguity, and wrong assumption in that spec, with high confidence. A spec can be exhaustively long and still incomplete. It can specify the wrong behavior precisely. It can omit error cases, edge conditions, and integration constraints that the agent will not independently discover, because the agent treats the spec as ground truth. The specification tells the AI *what* to build. It does not tell the AI *what it forgot to specify*. The quality improvement claimed by SDD vendors requires the spec itself to be correct and complete — which is the hard part of software engineering that specifications do not solve, they merely relocate.

5.6 Where Specifications May Still Have Value

Specifications may provide value through mechanisms our study does not measure: audit trails (what the code was *supposed* to do), durable documentation (reducing the knowledge gap as AI generates more code), and team alignment (shared understanding before implementation). These are organizational benefits, not defect-prevention benefits, and our data does not speak to them. There is also a timing distinction: a specification written *after* iterative validation may function differently from one written *before* any code exists. SDD tools treat the spec as the starting point, but a spec written before validation is a structured guess. Our data cannot distinguish specification-as-input from specification-as-output, but the distinction may matter for future research.

5.7 Vendor Evidence and Construct Gap

No SDD tool vendor has published empirical evidence for the quality claims tested here. The evidence base consists of first-principles reasoning ("clearer input → better output") and developer testimonials. GitHub describes Spec Kit as "an experiment" (Delimarsky, 2025) and publishes no effectiveness data. The third-party evaluations that do exist are negative: Böckeler found Spec Kit's overhead "overkill for the size of the problem" (Böckeler, 2025) Eberhardt found it roughly ten times slower than iterative development (Eberhardt, 2025).

The specification artifacts in our dataset are not generated by SDD tools. A text search of all 100,247 PR descriptions, titles, and file paths for `.specify/`, `.speckit/`, `.kiro/`, and `spec-kit` returns zero matches. The specification adoption we observe — rising from near zero to 14% over 2025–2026 — reflects organic specification behavior: linked issues, design documents, structured PR descriptions. We measure the *kind* of specification content that SDD tools claim to improve upon, scored on the same quality dimensions those tools prescribe, but the artifacts are not tool-generated.

This is a genuine limitation. SDD tools produce specifications in a specific format through a guided workflow, fed directly to an AI agent. Our proxy measures organic specification artifacts scored on the same dimensions. If the tool's format itself is the active ingredient — something beyond outcome clarity, error states, scope boundaries, acceptance criteria, data contracts, dependency context, and behavioral specificity — that would be a testable claim. Our data show that the content typically found in specifications, measured on the dimensions SDD tools prescribe, does not predict quality improvement.

An important implication: SDD tooling imposes real costs (specification-writing time, process overhead, organizational change). Teams adopting SDD on the basis of vendor claims are making investment decisions on unsubstantiated assertions. We do not argue that thinking about requirements is wasted effort. We argue that the *products* claiming to reduce defects through specification artifacts have not demonstrated that they do, and that the best available proxy evidence shows no such effect. Production-scale data from purpose-built SDD tools does not yet exist in the public domain, and vendors with the resources to produce it have not done so.

6 Threats to Validity

6.1 Construct Validity

Specification detection. Our `specd` classifier identifies specification artifacts (linked issues, structured descriptions), not the quality or depth of the specification process. A linked Jira ticket created to satisfy a process requirement is classified identically to a detailed design document produced after iterative refinement. If the claimed benefits of SDD come from the *process* rather than the *artifact*, our measure is too coarse to detect them.

Operationalization gap. We test claims made by purpose-built SDD frameworks (Spec Kit, Kiro) but operationalize specification presence using linked tickets and referenced design documents in open-source pull requests. These are not the same thing. A Spec Kit specification is a structured document generated through a guided workflow and fed directly to a coding agent; a linked Jira ticket is a project management artifact that may or may not contain behavioral requirements. We cannot prove these are equivalent concepts. Our operationalization is the broadest reasonable proxy available in observational data, but it may not capture the specific mechanism that SDD tools claim to provide. The high-quality spec subsample (top-quartile, scored on SDD-aligned dimensions) is the closest approximation, and it too shows no robust effect — but it is still a proxy, not the real thing.

Agentic workflow gap. Even for AI-tagged PRs with specifications, we do not know whether the specification was actually used as input to an AI agent or used for automated result verification. The spec may have been written for human consumption while the AI was used separately. True agentic SDD — where the agent reads the spec as its primary input, generates code from it, and validates against it — is not directly observable in our data. Our AI + high-quality spec subsample (42 identifying authors) is the closest proxy, but it is exactly that: a proxy.

Control group contamination. Our control group (PRs without detected specification artifacts) may include PRs where specifications existed but were not referenced in the PR metadata — shared in Slack, discussed verbally, stored in external tools, or simply not linked. Similarly, AI assistance without co-author tags would be invisible. Both forms of contamination would attenuate any treatment effect toward the null. We cannot estimate the extent of this contamination. However, if informal specification (verbal discussion, unlinked documents) produces equivalent outcomes to formal specification artifacts, this itself undermines the SDD value proposition. SDD

vendors claim that their tooling and artifacts produce measurably better outcomes — not that thinking about requirements helps relative to not thinking at all. If "just talking about it" is as effective as a structured specification framework, the framework adds no value.

Specification quality scoring. Quality scores are generated by an LLM-based rubric (Claude Haiku) without validation against human expert judgment. The rubric assesses formal quality — whether the specification text contains outcome descriptions, error states, acceptance criteria, and so on — but not necessarily functional quality. A specification can score highly on all seven dimensions and still specify the wrong behavior, omit critical domain constraints, or describe a solution to the wrong problem. LLM-based evaluation is the method that SDD tools themselves use to process specifications, and our seven dimensions align with the template elements prescribed by Spec Kit and Kiro. But this alignment means our scoring shares whatever blind spots those templates have. Furthermore, the scoring was applied only to PRs with substantial description text, creating a non-random subsample.

AI detection. We identify AI-assisted PRs via co-author tags, which are voluntarily added. The false-negative rate is unknown. If many untagged PRs involved AI assistance, the AI/human comparison (H5) would be diluted toward the null.

Defect detection. The SZZ algorithm traces from fix commits to bug-introducing commits via `git blame`. da Costa et al. (Costa et al., 2017) found that basic SZZ misattributes 46–71% of bug-introducing changes depending on the project. Known limitations include: attributing bugs to refactoring commits, missing multi-commit introductions, and failing to detect defects that were never fixed within the observation window. We use the basic SZZ variant rather than more accurate alternatives (RA-SZZ, MA-SZZ) for implementation simplicity across 103 repositories. If SZZ misattribution is non-differential with respect to specification presence — as we expect, since there is no mechanism by which SZZ accuracy would vary with specification status — measurement error attenuates true associations toward the null, reducing power but not creating spurious reversed effects. However, the high misattribution rate means that small true effects may be undetectable in our data.

6.2 Internal Validity

Confounding by indication is the primary threat, and our within-author design specifically addresses it by comparing each author's spec'd PRs to their own unspec'd PRs. However, within-author confounding remains possible if authors systematically select *different types* of tasks for specification vs. no specification, and those task types differ in defect propensity independent of specification.

Time-varying confounding. An author's skill, tooling, and project context may change over the observation period. The within-author estimator assumes time-invariant author effects.

6.3 External Validity

Open-source sample. All 119 repositories are open-source. SDD tools are primarily marketed toward commercial engineering teams. The specification practices, review cultures, and defect patterns in open-source may differ systematically from commercial contexts.

Convenience sample. Repositories were not randomly selected. Results cannot be generalized beyond the sample.

Pre-agentic era. Most PRs in the dataset predate the widespread availability of agentic AI coding tools (2025–2026). The claimed benefits of SDD may be specific to agentic workflows that are not well-represented in our data. We partially address this: the dataset contains 2,650 non-bot AI-tagged PRs (33.6% spec'd, after bot exclusion), the closest available proxy for agentic workflows. Within this subsample, specs show no effect on bugs ($p = 0.98$) or rework ($p = 0.33$), and high-quality specs show a suggestive but fragile protective effect (−4.8pp, $p = 0.045$, 107 identifying authors). However, the effect vanishes when comparing AI specs broadly ($p = 0.984$) for a stable estimate, and we cannot rule out that true agentic workflows — where the agent reads the spec as its primary input rather than a human writing code with optional AI assistance — would produce different results.

6.4 Statistical Conclusion Validity

Multiple comparisons. We test five hypotheses without correction. At $\alpha = 0.05$, approximately 0.25 false positives are expected.

Power for AI interaction. The scope-constraint interaction (H5) is identified from only 189 authors with variation in both specification and AI use. This test may be underpowered for small effects.

7 Conclusion

Spec-driven development tools make five specific, testable claims: specifications reduce defects, prevent rework, improve code quality through clearer requirements, and constrain AI-generated code scope. Production-scale data from purpose-built SDD tools is not yet publicly available. We test the claims using the best available proxy: 89,599 pull requests across 119 open-source repositories, where specification artifacts are scored on the same quality dimensions that SDD tools prescribe, using within-author fixed-effects estimation.

Zero of five hypotheses are supported. The naive association between specifications and defects is reversed (specifications accompany *more* defects); after within-author controls, the most parsimonious interpretation is confounding by indication. Specification quality has no meaningful effect on rework ($p = 0.767$). The claimed AI scope-constraint effect vanishes under within-author analysis. Six robustness checks all confirm the null. Adding specification presence to a JIT defect model contributes Δ Pseudo $R^2 = 0.00003$ ($p = 0.250$). Specification presence proxies for task complexity, not for quality improvement.

Three important caveats bound these findings. First, we test organic specification artifacts, not SDD tool-generated specifications — the construct gap is real (Section 6). Second, SZZ defect tracing has substantial measurement noise (46–71% misattribution), which attenuates true effects. Third, our open-source convenience sample may not generalize to commercial teams. Whether purpose-built SDD tooling would produce different results on commercial codebases remains an open question. The best available proxy evidence offers no support for the quality claims being made.

The dataset and analysis code are available at: `github.com/brennhill/delivery-gap-research`.

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